

Academic Ranking of World Universities – New Zealand university results

Background

The first Academic Ranking of World Universities (ARWU) results were published in 2003. The ranking was developed initially as a benchmarking exercise for the Shanghai Jiao Tong University. It has a specific focus on identifying which universities have elite research performance.

Method and criticisms

The ARWU considers universities that produce a significant number of indexed journal articles. Currently, more than 2,500 universities are scrutinised and the rankings for the top 1,000 universities are published. Up until 2016, only the rankings of the top 500 were published. In 2017, the published list was extended to include universities ranked 501-800 and in 2018 this was further extended to the top 1,000.

The ARWU measures the research performance of universities against four broad criteria: quality of education, quality of faculty, research output and per capita performance. It mainly identifies concentrations of quality research rather than measuring research performance per academic staff member. The six indicators of performance used to determine the final ARWU rankings are listed in Table 1, along with their weightings.

It is important to note that only the last of the six measures considers the size of the university. This does not favour New Zealand universities, in comparison with larger institutions overseas.

The bibliometric measures used in the ARWU favour universities with a strong focus on the sciences and medicine. Some of the measures favour the very elite institutions. For instance, it is highly unlikely that a New Zealand university would be able to employ a Nobel Prize winner as elite US and European universities generally employ these people. The ARWU rankings are therefore more biased towards elite US and European universities than university ranking systems in general.

A feature of the ARWU has been its stability in the component measures used over time. However, the transition to an annually updated list of highly cited researchers in 2016 has created some more variability in ranking for New Zealand universities.

The ARWU does not publish the individual rankings of universities outside of the top 100. Instead, the universities are listed in ranking bands.

Table 1

Component measures used in Academic Ranking of World Universities

Criteria	Indicator	Weight
Quality of education	Number of alumni of an institution winning Nobel Prizes or Fields medals	10%
Quality of faculty	Number of staff of an institution winning Nobel Prizes or Fields medals	20%
	Number of highly cited researchers in 21 broad subject categories	20%
Research output	Number of papers published in Nature or Science	20%
	Number of papers indexed in Science Citation Index-expanded and Social Science Citation Index	20%
Per capita performance	Per academic measure of the previous five measures	10%

Results

Table 2 presents the official published ranking bands for New Zealand universities in the ARWU.

Some of the key points of the ARWU rankings for New Zealand universities are:

- ▲ seven out of eight New Zealand universities were ranked inside the top 1,000 ARWU in 2025
- ▲ the University of Auckland is the top-ranked university
- ▲ in 2025, the ranking band for five of the New Zealand universities remained unchanged, while one moved up and one down in ranking band.

Table 2

Official published ARWU rankings for New Zealand universities 2003-2025

University	2003	2004	2005	2006	2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Auckland	201-300	202-301	203-300	201-300	203-304	201-302	201-302	201-300	201-300	151-200	201-300	201-300	201-300	151-200	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300
Canterbury			401-500	401-500	403-510	402-503	402-501	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500		301-400	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500
Otago	301-400	202-301	301-400	201-300	305-402	201-302	201-302	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	201-300	301-400	301-400	301-400	301-400	301-400	301-400	301-400	401-500	401-500	401-500
VUW			401-500	401-500	403-510	402-503	402-501	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500		301-400	301-400	301-400	301-400	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500
Waikato															601-700	701-800	701-800	701-800	701-800	701-800	801-900	801-900	701-800
Massey	301-400	404-502	401-500	401-500	305-402	303-401	402-501	401-500	401-500	401-500	401-500				501-600	501-600	601-700	601-700	701-800	601-700	701-800	801-900	801-900
AUT																901-1,000	701-800	901-1,000	701-800	701-800	801-900	801-900	901-1000
Lincoln															601-700	701-800	801-900	801-900	701-800	701-800	801-900		

Notes: 1. Up to 2016, results for the top 500 universities were published. This was increased to the top 800 in 2017 and the top 1,000 since 2018. 2. VUW = Victoria University of Wellington, AUT = Auckland University of Technology.

Source: www.shanghairanking.com

Tertiary System Performance Analysis
Te Pou Kaupapahere | Policy
Ministry of Education

This fact sheet is available from the Education
Counts website:

www.educationcounts.govt.nz/publications

© Crown Copyright Creative Commons by
Attribution 3.0 New Zealand Licence